

Constructing Arguments

It is true for both the Affirmative and Negative teams that at least part of your case will be composed of arguments (also called contentions or harms) that you present to prove your position. Well-constructed arguments are essential! You need at least four parts to every argument.

One – You must state your argument or claim clearly, concisely, briefly, and as a statement – not a question. Always number it – “Our first contention is....”

Two – You must provide evidence to support your argument. Sometimes, an argument will be complex, and you will need to structure it by dividing it into sub-points that you number. Always cite your source if you have one.

Three – You must explain the warrant – Explain why the data or evidence warrants or justifies the claim you are making. Tell how the evidence proves your claim.

Four --You must show the impact of this argument as it relates to the real world. Explain how your point helps or hurts the American public; explain how it changes the world

Let’s take a look at this in action. Let’s say we are debating the topic: *Cell phones are bad for teens*. Here is how you might structure an argument to support this proposition.

State argument/claim: Keep it simple & make it a statement.	Our first contention is cell phones lead to risky behaviors by teens.
Provide evidence: Whenever possible, give precise facts and stats. Also include a source whenever you can.	A. Bad pedestrian behavior – 45% more likely to have close call/accident when walking while talking on cell phone - Study U. of Alabama ’08. B. Used for cyber bullying – 1/3 of teens have been victimized by cyber bullying, - KidsHealth.org
Explain the warrant: Show how evidence warrants the or argument you’re making.	By allowing our teens to own cell phones, we subject them to risky behaviors that can hurt claim them; this shows that cell phones are bad for teens.
Show the Impact: Show how your claim would look and/or change in the real world.	By preventing teens from using cell phones, we will have healthier teens – with fewer deaths, less injuries, and fewer problems with self-esteem.

Now how would that look when you presented it? Look at the example below.

Example: *Our first contention is that cell phones lead to risky behaviors in our teens. We have two subpoints under this. Subpoint A – Teens use bad pedestrian behavior when on a cell phone. In fact, a study out of the University of Alabama in 2008 found that teens talking on cell phones while walking had a 45% greater chance of a close call or accident. Subpoint B – Another risky behavior is that cell phones are used for cyber bullying. In fact, KidsHealth.org found that 1/3 of teens today have been victimized by cyber bullying. By allowing our teens to own cell phones, we subject them to risky behaviors that can ultimately hurt them or others. These risky behaviors clearly demonstrate the resolution today that cell phones are bad. And when we limit use of cell phones, fewer teens will die, and they will experience fewer injuries and self-esteem issues.*

A **well-constructed argument** is an argument that sounds much stronger to the judge, and to be honest, it is more difficult to defeat. Well-constructed arguments also allow your judge to follow the debate more easily – it leads to a more organized debate.

The goal should be three well-constructed arguments which will make for a nice solid case.